

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/9: Responsible government: the constitutional architecture

PARLIAMENTARY GOVERNMENT

- +-- real executive is drawn from and responsible to the legislature
- +-- survival depends on confidence of the popularly elected House

UNION ARCHITECTURE

Articles 74-75 -> PM-led Council; collective responsibility to Lok Sabha

Article 77 -> conduct of Union business

Article 78 -> PM's duties toward the President

STATE PARALLELS

Articles 163-164 -> CM-led Council; responsibility to Legislative Assembly

Articles 166-167 -> State business and CM-Governor information duties

SYSTEM LOGIC

popular election -> legislative majority -> ministry -> continuing confidence -> accountability

TRAP: Parliament does not elect every minister separately.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/9: Nominal and real executive: advice, office and limited discretion

PRESIDENT: CONSTITUTIONAL HEAD

- +-- formal executive authority is vested in the President
- +-- normal exercise follows Article 74 ministerial advice

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PRIME MINISTER + COUNCIL: REAL POLITICAL EXECUTIVE

- +-- formulates policy and controls administration
- +-- remains responsible to Lok Sabha

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ADVICE CONTROL

- +-- President may once require reconsideration
- +-- reconsidered advice binds
- +-- Article 74(2) protects inquiry into advice, not every underlying act

LIMITED DISCRETION / CONVENTION ZONES

- +-- appoint PM where no clear majority exists
- +-- test confidence on the floor
- +-- assess dissolution where an alternative government may be possible

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/9: The parliamentary mechanism: fusion, membership and responsibility

CLASSIC FEATURES

- +-- dual executive: nominal head + real ministry
- +-- majority-party / coalition government
- +-- collective responsibility to Lok Sabha
- +-- political homogeneity or negotiated common programme
- +-- double membership: executive drawn from legislature
- +-- PM leadership
- +-- lower-House dissolution possibility
- +-- secrecy and Cabinet solidarity

COLLECTIVE RESPONSIBILITY

Cabinet decision -> all ministers publicly support or resign

loss of Lok Sabha confidence -> entire ministry resigns or seeks lawful dissolution

INDIVIDUAL RESPONSIBILITY

personal misconduct / departmental failure may trigger resignation without government fall

FUSION != absence of checks; courts, bicameralism, committees and elections remain.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/9: Confidence, no-confidence, dissolution and caretaker government

GOVERNMENT FORMS

- +-- majority ministry
- +-- coalition ministry
- +-- minority ministry with outside support

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CONTINUING TEST: DOES THE MINISTRY COMMAND LOK SABHA CONFIDENCE?

- +-- no-confidence motion
- +-- confidence motion
- +-- defeat on an issue expressly treated as confidence
- +-- floor test where majority is disputed

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IF CONFIDENCE IS LOST

- +-- resign
- +-- or advise dissolution, subject to assessment of alternatives

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CARETAKER CONVENTION

- +-- continuity until successor takes office
- +-- restraint in major irreversible policy unless necessity demands

TRAP: an internal party setback is not automatically loss of House confidence.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/9: Cabinet, Council of Ministers and Prime Ministerial leadership

COUNCIL OF MINISTERS: THE WIDER CONSTITUTIONAL BODY

- +-- Cabinet Ministers
- +-- Ministers of State, independent charge or attached
- +-- all ranks share collective responsibility

CABINET: SMALLER INNER DECISION CORE

- +-- major policy, legislation, budget, appointments and crisis decisions
- +-- supported by Cabinet Committees and Secretariat coordination

PRIME MINISTER

- +-- selects / allocates portfolios through advice
- +-- chairs Cabinet and coordinates ministries
- +-- leads majority or coalition and government business in Parliament
- +-- communicates between President and ministry under Article 78

DOMINANCE RISKS

party control + agenda control + ordinance / delegated legislation + weak scrutiny

LIMIT: presidentialisation is an analytical label; responsibility remains parliamentary.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/9: Parliamentary accountability: the corrective ecosystem

DAILY / PERIODIC SCRUTINY

- +-- Question Hour, debates, calling-attention devices and motions
- +-- budget, demands for grants, cut motions and financial control
- +-- committee examination of Bills, ministries and delegated legislation

FINANCIAL ACCOUNTABILITY

CAG reports -> Public Accounts Committee / other financial committees -> government response

POLITICAL ACCOUNTABILITY

opposition + media + federal second chamber + constituency pressure + elections

LEGAL / CONSTITUTIONAL ACCOUNTABILITY

judicial review + constitutional offices + statutory transparency and audit

WHY CONTROL MAY WEAKEN

- whip and anti-defection pressure -> limited dissent
- compressed sittings / rushed Bills -> reduced deliberation
- executive information advantage -> scrutiny gap

REFORM: time, information, committee capacity and opposition rights.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/9: Parliamentary and presidential systems compared precisely

AXIS	PARLIAMENTARY	PRESIDENTIAL
executive-legislature	fusion / interdependence	organisational separation
survival	continuing House confidence	fixed constitutional term
executive form	nominal + real executive	generally single real executive
membership	ministers usually legislators	executive normally outside legislature
removal	political no-confidence	exceptional impeachment process
strength	continuous accountability	tenure stability
risk	dominance / instability	deadlock / rigid mandate

INDIA

- +-- parliamentary responsibility + written supreme Constitution
- +-- federalism, judicial review and rights limit legislative majorities

UK contrast: orthodox parliamentary sovereignty and constitutional monarchy

US contrast: separately elected President and stronger personnel separation.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/9: Indian adaptation: stability, coalition and current design debate

WHY ADOPTED

familiar institutions + diversity accommodation + daily accountability + flexible change

MERITS

executive-legislature coordination

continuous responsibility

adaptable coalition bargaining

easy peaceful replacement

DEMERITS

Cabinet / PM dominance

instability in fragmented Houses

short-term politics and secrecy

weak separation and limited expertise

INDIAN ADAPTATIONS

coalition agreements -> common programme -> coordination committees

minority government -> issue-based confidence -> bargaining and instability risks

anti-defection -> stability support, but reduced legislative independence

CURRENT CONTROL

129th Amendment Bill, 2024 remains a committee-stage proposal.

Proposed Article 82A is not current law; use only for stability-accountability analysis.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/9: Prelims traps, verified PYQs and the Mains answer spine

PRELIMS CONTROL

Articles 74-75 -> Union Articles 163-164 -> States
collective responsibility -> Lok Sabha / Assembly, not both Houses
non-member minister -> maximum six consecutive months
Cabinet != entire Council of Ministers
no-confidence removes ministry, not Lok Sabha
President normally acts on advice; reconsideration is once

VERIFIED PYQS

2020 Prelims Q11; 2021 Prelims Q77
2018 GS-II Q13; 2023 GS-II Q4; 2024 GS-II Q3
Historical objective keys remain explicitly inferred; no key is fabricated.

MAINS SPINE

- 1 define responsible government through executive-legislature relationship
- 2 map Articles, nominal-real executive and confidence
- 3 explain responsibility and accountability instruments
- 4 compare presidential system; add Indian adaptation and dominance risks
- 5 propose scrutiny reforms and conclude: stability must serve responsibility.